THE NEXT BIG CLASH BETWEEN UDDHAV AND SHINDE FOR CONTROL OF THE SHIV SENA WILL BE THE CASH-RICH BRIHANMUMBAI CORPORATION POLLS, TO BE HELD IN OCTOBER

his retirement, Uddhav reappointed Mehta as his advisor, angering other babus. R.A. Rajeev was another IAS officer Uddhav banked on. Then commissioner of Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA), it was he who advised Uddhav to shift the controversial Metro car shed from Aarey Milk Colony to Kanjurmarg. It won Uddhav praise from environmentalists, but the Centre never handed over the Kanjurmarg land to the state, and Mumbai's Metro-3 project was stuck for two and a half years. Add to all this the Pawar stamp on proceedings, especially on major policy decisions—lifting lockdown norms, appointment of key bureaucrats and police officers, preference to sectors like sugar et al.

The sense of ideological dissonance hardly helped amid the gathering gloom. One flashpoint came on the night of April 16, 2020, in northern Konkan's Palghar district—off the national highway leading to Ahmedabad. Two Hindu seers and their driver were lynched as they were proceeding to Gujarat for a funeral, using back roads to avoid the highway rush. It was in reality a non-political incident: tribal vigilantes had mistaken them for child kidnappers. But as videos surfaced of the local police's inability to prevent the lynching, the BJP made political hay—painting it as official antipathy towards Hindutva. Against that backdrop, some moves by Uddhav troubled the Hindu right-wing gene that was part of the average Sainik's mindset: granting funds to madrasas, arresting independent MLA Ravi Rana for a Hanuman Chalisa recitation event. Uddhav even questioned the RSS's role in the freedom movement, earning more right-wing flak. "I understand Uddhavji taking potshots at the BJP. That is his politics. But I take his attack on the RSS as unwarranted," says Gaurav Singh, an RSS member from Mumbai. Uddhav's last-day renaming of Aurangabad as Sambhaji Nagar—something he had parried earlier—seemed more an act of belated penitence here.

Taken cumulatively, Uddhav's method seemed to consist essentially of a retreat on several fronts. Part of the reason for Uddhav's aloofness from the ground was health: he is a heart patient, with nine stent implants, and also had cervical spine surgery last November. A degree of caution during the pandemic was understandable. But instead of instituting an online networking system with his ministers and MLAs, he outsourced that task to his son, nephew and other trusted few, who wielded their new power in ways unaccountable to those who had built the party. No channels were made available to take feedback from lower-ranked party brass either, as he used to do in the past. And if a curious alienation marked his relations with his own party, those with his former ally saw a complete break. Uddhav chose to never have a dialogue with the BJP, avoiding all communication and banking entirely on Pawar's negotiation skills whenever it was called for—which is often in politics. Thus it was that the inheritor of the biggest political brand in Maharashtra, and one of the biggest in India, harmed his own bequest. It cannot be said that he did no good. He left a decisive imprint on fort conservation, in environmental policy and especially in Covid management—showing a sure administrative hand as he successfully steered what could have been the world's biggest hotspots through the century's greatest health scare. Nor is the tempering of Hindutva violence and rhetoric, in its original homeland and in fraught times, necessarily a liability—except within a hard adherent's worldview.

THE BATTLES AHEAD

The inevitable question after all the bruising drama is: what next? Uddhav, despite this stunning putsch, will still be a factor. But by anointing Shinde, the BJP is making it harder for Uddhav to ride back on a sympathy wave—the Sena, after all, *is* in power! On a tangent, it also curbs Shinde's ability to evolve as a parallel power centre: he will be completely dependent on the BJP. Instead of finishing the Sena with a formal split—which would be a long-drawn, self-harming battle for both factions—this does it by part-cooption, part-amputation. The last turn of the screw came when Fadnavis, who had said he would not formally join the government, was politely compelled by the BJP to discard any thoughts of splendid isolation and take charge as deputy CM—a role reversal none had imagined. The next axial point—elections to 20 resource-rich municipal corporations, 25 zilla parishads and 210 nagar parishads in October-November—is awaited now, for the BJP's next move to supplant its rival across the map. The first question about Uddhav everyone was asking over the past few days—'Will his government survive?'—has got a short, objective-type answer. No. But the greater question—'Can the Thackeray brand survive this self-inflicted calamity and retain its hold over the party and cadre?'—will be a messy essay-type answer, to be written over months and years. And there will be a Maratha named Eknath Shinde to complicate any pat narrative. ■

–with Anilesh S. Mahajan